among Elephants, have recounted how the act of internal or international migration was inevitably linked with the beginning of social emancipation.[22]

Migration has also been noted to be an important pathway to upward mobility through entrepreneurship. According to a study on twenty-one Dalit entrepreneurs:[23]

> the path to social mobility offered by entrepreneurship began with spatial mobility, most of all escaping rural India. Seemingly placid from the outside, its rigid hierarchies can suffocate those at its receiving end. The chaos and squalor of urban India provides at least a cloak of anonymity that keeps the possibility of individual initiative alive. Anonymity increases risk taking since failure has less social costs. Dalit entrepreneurs do not mind failing in places where their kith and kin are not around to mock their failed attempts, even though this might mean a weaker social network.

The puzzle then is why the low-ranking castes of India exhibit the lowest rates of semi-permanent or permanent migration, both in internal and international migration streams, when they have the most to gain by moving for long durations. One answer lies in the limited stock of physical capital that permits only short-duration migration strategies. Another theory argues that caste serves as a mechanism of rural insurance such that permanent departure from the village is costlier for the lowest-ranking castes that face greater income risk.[24] A more potent reason is limited informational networks that restrict access to new jobs and destinations. As previous chapters have shown, the migration networks fostered by priests, warriors and merchants over centuries gave their descendants a major informational advantage over the SCs and STs that is as important as the economic advantages in grabbing new opportunities. This is why, as per Census 2011, even though the all-India urbanization rate stood at 31 per cent, it was only 24 per cent among the SCs and 10 per cent among the STs.

The possibility of a ‘Great Migration’, as in the case of African-Americans in 20th century America, is remote as members of the lowest-ranking castes are far more evenly spread out over the countryside in India than the clustered location of African-Americans in the American South in the 19th century. In the USA, as Isabel Wilkerson noted in *The Warmth of*